LOGICAL FRAMEWORK ASSUMPTIONS

Assumptions reflect our recognition that there are factors beyond our control that are necessary for successful achievement of objectives at all levels of the project. The project design team must do its best to identify and assess critical assumptions. Major assumptions, risks, and contingencies should be assessed with project feasibility in mind.

In an Objective Tree, "if-then" hypotheses are show as a hierarchy that leads from Outputs to a Project's Goal. This hierarchy is incorporated into a Logical Framework's Narrative Summary column. While the reasoning in this first column of a Logical Framework captures key elements of what is necessary to achieve an important set of results, this picture is often incomplete.

Beyond a chain of intended results lies a set of conditions about which designers make assumptions that must also be valid for project results to be achieved. The Logical Framework demands transparency about these other factors. The matrix calls for their disclosure at every level of a results hierarchy, so that it is clear what risks might exist with respect to achieving a project's Purpose. The Assumptions column at the far right of a Logical Framework matrix documents these other factors. Together, the Narrative Summary and Assumptions columns of a Logical Framework tell us what the necessary and sufficient conditions are for success.

In the table below, the Narrative Summary of project hypotheses and results for a trade facilitation project is shown next to assumptions that a design team might have made for this project. The figure brings together the far left and right columns of a Logical Framework matrix as if the middle columns had been folded away to display bones of the project's design logic clearly. Arrows on the diagram illustrate how these two columns are to be read.

Narrative Summary		Assumptions
Goal Rapid, sustainable, broad-based economic growth		
Purpose Trade performance improved		*Affecting the purpose-to-goal link* • Growth of the domestic economy remains steady or improves
Sub-Purpose More efficient/cost-effective movement of goods across borders		*Affecting the sub-purpose-to-purpose link* • World prices for country's exports remain steady or improve • Volume and types of non-traditional exports continues to rise, even if only slightly
Outputs 1. Customs automation extended to land crossings 2. Trained customs staff at land border crossings increased 3. Expedited clearance introduced for accredited economic operators		*Affecting the output-to-purpose link* • Electrical service at land/road border crossings is available 24/7 most days • Trained customs staff are not reassigned away from land/border crossings once placed there
Inputs 1.1 Install computers, scanners, printers, electrical wiring and related equipment in 14 land crossing customs posts 2.1 Assign 28 trained/experienced additional customs staff to border posts; provide customs staff already working at those posts with training in automated systems and procedures 3.1 Distribute flyers and initiate local trade radio campaign in border crossing towns to promote accredited operators program 3.2 Introduce simplified "accredited economic operator" application procedure at land border crossing customs posts		*Affecting the input-to-output link* • Adequate number of experienced customs agents are willing to be reassigned to land/border posts from the capital city • Number of shippers that can and want to qualify for the accredited economic operators program meets or exceeds survey estimates